of God, for which he must overcome the original sin that stood in the way of such ‘reformation’.[7]

In practice, the process of conversion divided both human beings and the world into two realms, namely the spiritual and the temporal. The temporal world was given a shelf life until the second coming of Christ, whereas the spiritual was eternal. Until the second coming, the obligation of a true Christian was to constantly work towards overcoming the desires of the flesh so as to make the spirit and body more spiritual.[8] This meant that the process of conversion towards the object of reformation was a never-ending one for two reasons: first, the ‘original sin’ was too seductive to overcome and therefore, human beings would assuredly fail, thereby reinforcing their status as wretched sinners; and second, this process had to continue until the second coming.

The silver lining, if any, of this never-ending process of conversion was that the degree of conversion achieved in this world would determine the extent of freedom conferred in the next world. Importantly, those who had submitted themselves fully to God were beyond the reach of human authorities and hence, free from their control. Not only were they free from the restrictions imposed by any earthly authority, their submission to God gave them the ability to resist the desires of the flesh. However, in order to achieve complete submission to God and total freedom from secular authorities, faith in Christ was the only way since Christ had received divine grace. Without such grace, humans were themselves incapable of resisting the seductive lure of sin. Simply put, according to Catholic belief, for all humans, Christ was the only way to reach God.

In the medieval age, various Christian monastic orders that revolved around the institutionalisation of this process of conversion influenced the Church significantly. Since these Christian monastic orders had dedicated their entire lives to the achievement of this divine purpose through rigorous practice, their supposedly exalted spiritual position, according to them, also gave them power over the earthly society and secular authority in order to convert them. The Church, being alive to the austerities of monks, absorbed them as bishops or elevated them to positions of leadership within the Church. The consequence of this nexus between monastic orders and the Church was the pursuit of reformation of the society in the image of the monastic community. De Roover has referred to this milestone as ‘the monasticization of the Church’ and, therefore, Christendom itself. Given